55

Indic Hybridity

What needs reclaiming in the name of Bhagat Singh is the hybrid Indo-Islamic world that is fast disappearing. This is a world where Sanskrit-based languages charmingly and teasingly intermingle with Turkish, Persian and Arabic dialects, and this world needs to be rescued for the good of India's cosmopolitan society. A world where it was not unknown for a Rajput princess to marry a Mughal ruler—replaced now with a moral universe where even the pictorial depiction of such historic events is deemed to be nothing short of sacrilege and infamy.[1] Let us not forget how after an ill-thought-out fast-track citizenship law was passed for non-Muslim migrants from three neighbouring countries, which excluded the right of Muslim migrants to register as citizens of India, protests broke out across. A Hindu nationalist agenda to marginalize the 200 million Indians who follow Islam led to the death of six people in the north-east and reports of up to a 100 injured in Delhi in December 2019.[2]

The last thing that Bhagat Singh's India could have been associated with was sectarianism. It was not for this that he sacrificed his young life. Kama Maclean explains this well when she asserts, 'The HSRA and Naujawan Bharat Sabha worked on a very different trajectory, eschewing communalism with a strident secularist critique which forbade its members from membership of religious or communal organisations . . .'.[3] Jinnah defended Bhagat Singh in Parliament for this reason. Yet, as Maclean points out, it was 'a revelation to many when A.G. Noorani wrote at length in his book of M.A. Jinnah's defence of Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev in the Legislative Assembly in 1929, objecting to the bill introduced to allow the business of the Lahore conspiracy case to be tried in absentia by a